convolute and breed, without the possibility of a clear true verdict ever being heard or respected. This is my life now, and I bring it to you neither with a shrug nor a whimper. You can only set the record straight where you can and get on with the job of forgetting yourself in the name of bigger causes.

A large part of my job, when not harrying the banks, has been to reveal exactly where the blood has been spilled in modern wars and state-sponsored invasions. It is a large task, and one that can only really be completed by the public at large. We don't splash stories, we convey information, and it is the task – a task that will take years – of individuals, researchers, journalists and lawyers, to look into the data and see what it means. Our work with the newspapers was intended to be a stimulus: the material was vast and was being offered to the public. How it can be us, or the enquiring public, that has blood on their hands, as opposed to the generals and governors who prosecute these wars, is a matter for clairvoyant abstraction. But let us just say that the Afghan logs and the Iraqi diaries cannot be owned by either would-be conquering armies or by evil dictators. They are not theirs to own; they are part of the fabric of the world's reality. Gates and others may not like the fact that they cannot be in possession of that reality, but indeed they cannot, unless they, and their opposite numbers, wish to be known as Big Brother. When forced to tell the truth, in a letter to the Senate a fortnight later, on 16 August 2010, Defense Secretary Gates informed members that 'the review to date has not revealed any sensitive intelligence sources and methods compromised by this disclosure'; the link that was originally inferred between me and 'blood on hands' was falsified from the horse's mouth.

Red herrings and smears aside, the logs make a crucial contribution towards the understanding of the war. They reveal the way the real incidents on the ground unfolded, while also alerting the public to how these incidents were often downplayed in statements about them, whether coming from the military or reported in the media. Again and again, civilian casualties are minimised or misreported. The moral thing to do, and this is moral work for everyone, is to examine the actual field report and compare it with what was said later, and what you find, too often for any kind of comfort, are situations where innocent people were killed and not acknowledged. If a building, for instance, was suspected of being a hideout for Taliban leaders, targeted and bombed, and it later turned out to be a